

WEEK 4 LESSON GUIDE

WONDER

BIG IDEA

We worship because God can heal.

BIBLE

Psalm 69:13–18, 147:3; Luke 13:10–17

ABOUT THIS WEEK

Like shimmering coral reefs full of life, God's healing power brings beauty and restoration in unexpected ways. This week, we'll see how God hears our cries for help and how Jesus healed a woman who responded with heartfelt praise. This helps us remember that, no matter what we're facing, we can celebrate with wonder and confidence, knowing **we worship because God can heal**.

WHAT? What are we talking about?



See the
Accessibility Hacks



IMAGE | The Great Barrier Reef

- We've been exploring some of the world's wonders as we think about worship and how to make it a bigger part of our lives. We've talked about Mount Everest, the Grand Canyon, and Victoria Falls. Today, we're looking at the Great Barrier Reef.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, show an image of the Great Barrier Reef, like [this one](#) from Unsplash. These images are free for you to use under the [Unsplash license](#). [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- The Great Barrier Reef is the largest reef system in the world. It's made of almost 3,000 individual coral reefs in the northwest region of Australia. This reef system is so large that you can see it from space! It's truly a wonder of the world.
- Not only is the Great Barrier Reef amazing to see and experience, but it's also home to many different types of plants and animals. It is an important part of the local environment. But there's a problem. Over half of the Great Barrier Reef has died since 1995. Rising water temperatures have caused the coral to bleach, making it uninhabitable for many of the plants and animals that live there.
- Thankfully, the local government and conservationists around the world have a plan to save the reef. It'll take some time and a lot of work, but there's hope that one day, the reef will return to its past glory.

ACTIVITY | Reef Resilience

- Restoring a broken system like a coral reef takes time, resources, and resilience. People have to be willing to put in the work even when it's tough or feels like a lost cause. I'll need a few volunteers to demonstrate some resilience.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** For this activity, you will need a [large tub](#) or [storage bin](#), water (alternate option: [ball pit balls](#)), and a large space. Invite four volunteers to take off

their shoes but leave their socks on. Have each player lie down on their back with their feet up in the air. Fill the tub with water or ball pit balls and have the players hold it up with their feet. Players must work together to remove their own socks one by one without spilling the bucket.

- A lot happened here, right? To do well in this game, you need a combination of teamwork and resilience. You had to be able to rely on your team to hang in there while you took on an impossible challenge.
- The scientists and conservationists working around the clock to save the Great Barrier Reef are just that—resilient! They're willing to hold on for as long as they need. They'll grind away and keep showing up to save what matters to them. They see the bigger picture and want to restore the Great Barrier Reef to its complete glory—the way it *should* be.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - **What is one sea creature you would want to swim with? Which ones would you want to avoid?**
 - ***When were you tempted to quit something because it felt like a lost cause? What happened, and how did you show resilience?**

POLL | Have you ever... ?

- I think we can all relate to the feeling of hoping for restoration after a difficult time. Maybe you've seen people you care about go through a hard time that you wish they didn't have to go through. In those moments, you might want to see things restored to exactly how they were before. I'm curious if there's been something *you've* ever needed to heal from.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Poll your teenagers' responses to the following questions. You could ask them to raise their hands, stand up, or shout their answers.*
 - **Have you ever had to heal from a physical injury?**
 - **A relationship?**
 - **A meaningful object?**
 - **A memory?**
- We long for healing from broken situations and those that just need mending. Maybe the potential in our minds doesn't live up to reality. Thankfully, restoration through resilience is a possibility—it's even a promise made by God. When we experience damage or brokenness, we can look to God for help.

SO WHAT? Why does it matter to God and to us?



See the High School Hacks



SCRIPTURE | Psalm 69:13–18

- This month, we've been turning to the book of Psalms to help us understand worship. These poems and songs help us explore our relationship with God through the highs and lows.



See the Hacks →

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Psalm 69:13–18.
- Can you relate to this? I know I can. So many times in my life, I wanted God to rescue me. I'm pretty sure this feeling is universal. So much good happens in our lives, but have you ever noticed how we tend to focus on our most challenging needs over everything else?
- In this psalm, we get a great example of how we can respond when we're in the middle of a hurtful experience—we can turn to God. This psalmist knew what was possible, what was waiting for them on the other side of this challenge. Even though it hurt, they believed God would help them get through it. The author of this psalm chose to worship and write these words to inspire future generations. When relationships or situations are broken or not quite right, we can look to God for help, guidance, and restoration.
- This type of prayer shows someone who has a relationship with God knows that change can come in a different way than we might initially expect. The psalmist trusted in God to lead and protect them in the darkest moments. They saw life on the other side and knew there was more beyond what they were experiencing. They chose to be honest about what they needed and hoped for—God's restoration.
- These words can help us recover from difficult circumstances—they can help us be resilient. They remind us that God can heal no matter what we're facing.

QUESTION | When do you ask for healing?

- A lot of us have prayed these kinds of prayers. They're typically our first responses when we feel hurt or experience a damaged relationship.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Give students a few moments to turn to their neighbor and ask the question. After a minute, ask a few students to share their answers with the group.
- Turn to your neighbor and answer this question: **When do you ask for healing?**
- We all need healing, which can happen in all kinds of ways.
 - You might have a broken heart, and you feel like it can't be put back together.
 - You might have experienced a deep conflict with your best friend and be wondering if life will ever feel normal again.
 - Maybe you made a decision that made you question what you thought you knew to be true about yourself.
- The way we ask for healing will depend on what we need. Whether we're experiencing a broken heart or a broken idea of who we are, we know God can restore anything we need.

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SCRIPTURE | Luke 13:10–17

- In the same way that we long for healing now, people longed for healing during Jesus' time. There's this story in the Gospel of Luke about a woman who was healed by Jesus in an unexpected way.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Luke 13:10–17.
- Jesus was teaching when he noticed a woman. She had a condition that kept her bent over and unable to stand up straight. This must have affected so many

parts of her life, including her relationships. The common thought at the time was that people with these types of ailments, injuries, or disabilities must have done something to deserve it. So, people who saw her may have judged her from a distance.

- But when Jesus saw her, he spoke a few words to her, and she was suddenly healed. Eighteen years of chronic pain dissolved away because of Jesus. What was her response? Worship.
- The second she recognized that Jesus had healed her, she started to worship God because of what had happened. But not everyone watching was excited. While she celebrated her new chance at life, the religious leaders were upset with Jesus.
- They accused Jesus of violating the Sabbath—a special day when no one was supposed to work. They couldn't wrap their heads around the way Jesus healed this woman. They expected God to stick to *their* rules and expectations, and when that didn't happen, they looked for any reason to discredit Jesus' great miracle.
- Instead of worshiping in response to this incredible experience, some questioned and criticized Jesus' work. They were all in the same room looking at the same wonder, but only some chose to respond in worship.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - ***How do you respond when situations don't go the way you expect?**
 - ***Why do you think the Bible includes Psalms where the writer struggles with life not going their way?**
 - **What are some of the characteristics you think the woman from the story today had in order to approach Jesus for healing?**



Share your story

STORY | A Story of God's Unexpected Healing

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Tell a story about a time in your life when you unexpectedly experienced God's healing. Share about how you wanted to be healed and compare it to how God healed you. When did you notice what happened? How did you feel? What did you do in response? You can also ask a volunteer to share.*
- When we ask God to heal us, it can happen in unexpected ways. There's a tendency to think of healing as an immediate fix and cure, imagining it happening as it did for the woman in today's story—but that's not always the case. Sometimes, God heals in entirely different ways. Most often, our healing takes time.
- While we tend to focus on the incredible stories of God healing physical ailments, the healing God promises goes deeper—it's spiritual and emotional, too. That type of healing doesn't happen overnight—it can take a long time.
- As we grow closer to God, we're invited to heal in unexpected ways. God's healing is ongoing, not a one-time deal. By building habits that move us closer to God and make us more like Jesus, we can experience this healing that only God can provide.
- God gives us a chance to experience healing well beyond what we could ever

hope or imagine. Whatever healing we experience from God—physical, emotional, or spiritual—we can respond with worship and praise, knowing that God makes the impossible, *possible*.

- Like the woman Jesus healed or the psalmist who experienced God's restoration, we can ask God to heal us and worship while we wait. **We worship because God can heal.**

NOW WHAT? What does God want us to do about it?



REFLECTION | Healing Helps

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Before the program, print out the [handout](#) in the Week 4 folder.
- What do you do if you need healing? How do you respond when there is brokenness around you? Here are a few ways you can worship in moments of hurt.
 - **MOVE CLOSER TO JESUS:** The woman Jesus healed was near him. She did her best to grow closer to God and was committed to growing that relationship despite her pain and the barriers she experienced. When we're in pain or need healing, it's natural to want to move away and fix matters on our own. We can live differently and take steps closer to Jesus through prayer, studying Scripture, and reevaluating our habits and priorities. When you need healing, move closer to Jesus.
 - **CALL OUT FOR HELP:** Asking for help can seem awkward or tough, but healing can be done in community. There are people around you who want to see you thrive and stay resilient through your pain. They want to see you restored and make a great comeback. Pray and ask God to help heal you, and look to the people around you for strength. Let them be reminders of God's presence and love in your life as you keep moving through the process of healing.
 - **TRUST WHEN IT DOESN'T MAKE SENSE:** We might pray for healing, and it might not happen how we expect. We may want to give up or turn our backs on God, like how some of the people who watched Jesus heal chose to respond. It takes strength to give God **even more** of our trust in these times of grief. We can admit that we don't understand and that we can't see the end of a difficult situation. We can hold our expectations loosely and trust God to help us grow—even if it doesn't make sense to us in the moment.
 - **WORSHIP BECAUSE GOD HEALS:** Like the psalmist and the woman Jesus healed, worship can be our first response to healing. Worship when a relationship is healed. Worship when an injury is restored. Worship when you regain confidence in yourself. Worship when you find your hope again. Worship any time you experience God's healing. **We worship because God can heal.**

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are



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- **Read Psalm 147:3. What do you think it means that God binds up our wounds?**
- ***What are some ways you have experienced different kinds of healing in your own life? How can healing show up in different ways?**

RESPONSE | I Am Healing

- When you're hurt, you might reach for a bandage. They're a universal sign that you've been injured and are healing in some way. Bandages don't just cover up a wound, though. They actually help the healing process.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** For this response, you will need [neon adhesive bandages](#) for every person, tables, and permanent markers. Set up a few tables with the bandages and permanent markers. Be sure teenagers can put on the bandages themselves. Have each student take a bandage and write "I am healing" before placing it somewhere visible on their clothes or body.
- Take some time to think about the ways you've experienced healing, either physically, emotionally, or spiritually. Then, when you're ready, you can take one of these bandages and write "I am healing" as a reminder of God's ongoing healing. Healing is a process and requires resilience. Remember that God wants the best for us, and with God, we will be healed, although it might not look exactly how we expect.
- After writing on your bandage, place it somewhere visible. First, these bandages can remind us that we're not the only ones in need of healing. Second, we can worship God for all of the ways the people around us have been healed. From this day on, every time we see a bandage, we can worship God for healing us.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups.
 - **What is an area where you can practice looking for healing, even if it feels difficult?**
 - **For this week, what is one way you can remind yourself that we worship because God is holy?**



Spend Time
With God



MUSIC | "God Will Heal Our Wounds" (Common Hymnal)

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Play the song "[God Will Heal Our Wounds](#)" (Common Hymnal) and invite students to worship and thank God for all the ways they have been healed. Make sure you have purchased any required licenses. [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- As we wrap up this series, I hope we've discovered something about worship. It's more than singing songs or lifting our hands. It's a response to the incredible way God moves in our lives. When we worship, we can align ourselves with God's character and plan for the world. Plus, worship is a way for us to move closer to God as we continue to experience the ongoing healing offered to us.
- **We worship because God is holy, God provides, and God is faithful.** God is also working to restore us and our world. **We worship because God can heal.**